

FIGURES OF SPEECH

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simile
oxymoron
hyperbole
personification
metaphor
idiom
alliteration
pun
onomatopoeia

1. Simile

A direct comparison between two unlike things using the words 'like' or 'as'. It creates a vivid image by showing how one thing resembles another.

Example:

The fighter was as brave **as** a lion.

Her voice sounded **like** a broken record.

2. Metaphor

An indirect comparison where a word or phrase is applied to an object or action to which it is not literally applicable. It essentially states that one thing is another.

Example:

He is a lion.

The world is a stage. (*The world is compared to a stage.*)

Laughter is the best medicine.

3. Personification

Attributing human qualities, actions, or characteristics to inanimate objects, abstract ideas, or animals.

Example:

The wind howled mournfully outside.

The sun smiled down on the children.

4. Hyperbole

The use of extreme exaggeration for emphasis or effect; it is not meant to be taken literally.

Example:

I've told you a million times not to do that!

I'm so hungry I could eat a horse.

5. Alliteration

The repetition of the same sound or letter at the beginning of closely connected words. It is primarily used for emphasis and rhythmic effect.

Example:

The silent sea shells shone slowly. (Repetition of the 's' sound)

Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled pepper.

6. Onomatopoeia

The formation of a word from a sound associated with what is named; words that imitate the natural sounds of something.

Example:

The snake made a hissing sound.

The clock went tick-tock.

The bee buzzed past my ear.

7. Oxymoron

The combination of two words that are opposite in meaning or contradictory to create a new, often paradoxical, expression.

Example:

Original copy (Original is usually unique; a copy is not.)

Bitter-sweet memories.

Open secret.

8. Pun (Paronomasia)

A play on words that suggests two or more meanings, or exploits similar-sounding words that have different meanings, usually for a humorous or rhetorical effect.

Example:

A bicycle can't stand on its own because it is two-tired
(*too tired*)

I'm thinking of becoming a doctor, but I don't have
enough patients. (*patience*)

9. Irony

A figure of speech in which the intended meaning is opposite to that expressed by the words used. There are three main types:

Verbal Irony: Saying the opposite of what you mean (e.g., calling a bad situation "lovely").

Situational Irony: The outcome is the opposite of what was expected.

Dramatic Irony: The audience knows something the characters do not.

Example(Verbal Irony):

Upon seeing a very heavy downpour, one might say, "What beautiful weather we're having today!"

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Example(Situational Irony):

The marriage counsellor has filed for divorce.

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Example(Dramatic Irony):

In a mystery movie, a detective is hunting for a serial killer. The audience has already seen the killer's face and knows his secret identity. The killer, posing as a helpful citizen, offers the detective a ride home, saying, "Don't worry, I know this city like the back of my hand."

10. Synecdoche

A figure of speech in which a part is made to represent the whole or vice versa.

Example:

All hands (sailors) on deck.

(Part for the Whole)

India (the cricket team) lost the match.

(Whole for the Part)

11. Metonymy

A figure of speech that replaces the name of a thing with the name of something else with which it is closely associated. It is not a part-to-whole relationship (like synecdoche) but an associated idea.

Example:

The Crown (The Monarchy/Royal Authority) will decide the matter.

He is a man of the cloth (The Clergy/Religious Vows).

12. Apostrophe

A figure of speech in which a speaker directly addresses someone (or something) that is not present or cannot respond, such as an abstract idea, a deceased person, or an inanimate object.

Example:

Oh, liberty, what crimes are committed in your name!
Twinkle, twinkle, little star, how I wonder what you are.

13. Litotes (Understatement)

A figure of speech in which the negation of its opposite expresses an affirmative statement. Essentially, it is a deliberate understatement, often used for emphasis, ironic effect, or to express modesty.

Structure: It typically uses the formula "not bad," "not uncommon," or "not untrue."

Example:

"The food was not unappetizing." (*Meaning: The food was quite appetising/delicious.*)

"The damage caused by the storm was no small matter." (*Meaning: The damage was immense and serious.*)

14. Assonance (Vowel Repetition)

The repetition of identical or similar vowel sounds in neighbouring words within a sentence or phrase, especially in stressed syllables.

Examples:

- How **solid** is the **soul** **of** the gro**an**ing ground!
(Repetition of the long **o** sound.)
- The **old** man **roamed** **over** the st**on**es.

15. Consonance (Consonant Repetition)

The repetition of identical or similar consonant sounds in neighbouring words. Crucially, this repetition can occur anywhere within the words—at the beginning, middle, or end—unlike alliteration, which strictly requires repetition at the beginning.

Example:

The **p**illows **p**ulled the **s**lee**p**er into the **l**azy dream.
(Repetition of the **p** and **l** sounds.)

He **stru**ck**** a **stre**ak**** of bad **lu**ck**** through **th**e** th**ick**** and **thin**. (Repetition of the **t** and **ck** sound.)